

Chapter 25 — "Spot the Niphal" Passage Exercise

Genesis 3, 6, and 21 · The Garden, the Flood Prelude, and Beersheba

Most highlighted verbs are Niphal forms. For each one, first answer Is it Niphal? (Yes / No). If Yes: parse conjugation, PGN, and root, then state the semantic function (Passive / Reflexive / Middle / Simple Action). If No: identify the correct stem and parse fully. Part C contains distractor verbs — not Niphal. Answer key begins on the page marked "Answer Key".

Passage A — Genesis 3:5–10

3:5

וַהֲיִיתֶם כְּאֱלֹהִים יְדֹעֵי טוֹב וָרָע כִּי יָדַע אֱלֹהִים כִּי בַיּוֹם אֲכָלְכֶם מִמֶּנּוּ וּנְפָקְחֻ עֵינֵיכֶם

"...for God knows that in the day you eat of it your eyes will [1] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
1	וּנְפָקְחֻ				

3:6

וְנֹחַמְדָּ הָעֵץ לְהַשְׂכִּיל

"...and that the tree was desirable to make one wise."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
2	וְנֹחַמְדָּ				

3:7

וַתִּפְקְחֻנָּה עֵינֵי שְׁנֵיהֶם

"Then the eyes of both of them [3] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
3	וַתִּפְקְחֻנָּה				

3:10

וְאִירָא כִּי־עִירָם אָנֹכִי וְאֶחָבָא

"I was afraid, because I was naked, and [4] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
4	וְאֶחָבָא				

Passage B — Genesis 6:6–12

6:6

וַיִּנָּחַם יְהוָה כִּי־עָשָׂה אֶת־הָאָדָם בָּאָרֶץ

"And the LORD [5] ____ that he had made man on the earth."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
5	וַיִּנָּחַם				

6:7

נַחֲמַתִּי כִּי עָשִׂיתֶם

"I [6] ____ that I made them."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
6	נַחֲמַתִּי				

6:11

וַתִּשְׁחַת הָאָרֶץ ... וַתִּמְלֵא הָאָרֶץ חָמָס

"The earth [7] ____ ... and the earth [8] ____ with violence."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
7	וַתִּשְׁחַת				
8	וַתִּמְלֵא				

6:12

וְהִנֵּה נִשְׁחָתָה כִּי־הִשְׁחִית כָּל־בָּשָׂר

"and behold, it [9] ____, for all flesh had corrupted its way."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
9	נִשְׁחָתָה				

6:21

וְהָיָה לָהֶם לְאֹכֶל וְלָהֶם לְאֹכֶל יֵאָכֵל

"it shall be food for you and for them — it shall [10] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
10	יֵאָכֵל				

Passage C — Genesis 21:23–31

21:23

הִשְׁבַּעָה לִּי בְּאֵלֵהִם הִנֵּה

"[11] ____ to me by God here."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
11	הִשְׁבַּעָה				

21:24

וַיֹּאמֶר אַבְרָהָם אֲנֹכִי אֲשַׁבֵּעַ

"And Abraham said, 'I [12] ____.'"

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
12	אֲשַׁבֵּעַ				

21:31

כִּי שָׁם נִשְׁבְּעוּ שְׁנֵיהֶם

"For there [13] ____ both of them."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
13	נִשְׁבְּעוּ				

Bonus — Genesis 21:3, 21:8

21:3

אֲשֶׁר-נִוְלַד-לּוֹ

"who had been born to him"

21:8

וַיִּגְדַּל הַיֶּלֶד וַיִּגְמַל

"And the child grew and was weaned."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
B1	נִוְלַד				
B2	וַיִּגְמַל				

Part C — Distractor Check

These three verbs come from the same passages. None are Niphal. Answer "No" for Niphal? and complete the full parse.

3:6

וַתֵּרָא הָאִשָּׁה כִּי טוֹב הָעֵץ לְמַאֲכֹל

"So when the woman [D1] ____ that the tree was good for food."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
D1	וַתֵּרָא				

6:6

כִּי עָשָׂה אֶת-הָאָדָם בְּאֶרֶץ

"that he [D2] ____ mankind on the earth."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
D2	עָשָׂה				

21:8

וַיִּגְדַּל הַיֶּלֶד

"And [D3] ____ the child."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
D3	וַיִּגְדַּל				

Items 5–6 (■■■■■■■■■■ / ■■■■■■■■■■) are both from ■■■■■■, a verb that occurs almost exclusively in the Niphal. Items 11–13 all parse as Reflexive from ■■■■■■ — notice how Imperative, Imperfect, and Weqatal all express the same oath-swearing action.

Score: 13 main + 2 bonus = 15 total. 13–15 = excellent | 9–12 = review the paradigm | below 9 = revisit §23.3–23.13

Conjugation Coverage

Conjugation	Verbs
Wayyiqtol (5)	#3, #5, #7, #8, B2
Weqatal (5)	#1, #6, #9, #13, B1
Imperfect (2)	#10, #12
Participle (1)	#2
Imperative (1)	#11
Distractors (3)	D1 (Qal Wayyiqtol 3fs), D2 (Qal Perfect 3ms), D3 (Qal Wayyiqtol 3ms)

Reflection Questions

1. Every Niphal in Passage A (Gen 3) involves eyes, hiding, or desire. What does the Niphal contribute to the theological message of the Fall narrative?
2. In Gen 6:6–7, God is the subject of a Niphal-only verb (■■■■■). What does this choice tell us about how the narrator portrays God's emotional response?
3. Compare Gen 3:5 (■■■■■■■■■■ — "will be opened," Middle/Tolerative) with Gen 3:7 (■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■■ — "were opened," Middle). Is the function identical in both? What difference in nuance, if any, does the shift from weqatal to wayyiqtol suggest?

Answer Key

Passages with correct answers shown in the green row below each verb.

Passage A — Genesis 3:5–10

3:5

וַיֵּיתֶם כְּאֵלֵהִים יָדַעַי טוֹב וְרָע כִּי יָדַע אֱלֹהִים כִּי בַיּוֹם אֲכַלְכֶּם מִמֶּנּוּ וְנִפְקְחוּ עֵינֵיכֶם

"...for God knows that in the day you eat of it your eyes will [1] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
1	וְנִפְקְחוּ				see ↓
✓	וְנִפְקְחוּ	Weqatal	3cp	פִּקַּח	Middle — will be opened

3:6

וְנִחְמַד הָעֵץ לַהֲשִׁילָהּ

"...and that the tree was desirable to make one wise."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
2	וְנִחְמַד				see ↓
✓	וְנִחְמַד	Participle ms	ms	חָמַד	Passive — desirable (substantival ptc.)

3:7

וַתִּפְקְחוּהָ עֵינֵי שְׁנֵיהֶם

"Then the eyes of both of them [3] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
3	וַתִּפְקְחוּהָ				see ↓
✓	וַתִּפְקְחוּהָ	Wayyiqtol	3fp	פִּקַּח	Middle — they were opened

3:10

וַאֲיֹרָא כִּי־עִירָם אָנֹכִי וְאֶחָבָא

"I was afraid, because I was naked, and [4] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
4	וְאֶחָבָא				see ↓
✓	וְאֶחָבָא	Wayyiqtol	1cs	חָבָא	Reflexive — I hid myself

Passage B — Genesis 6:6–12

6:6

וַיַּנְחֶם יְהוָה כִּי־עָשָׂה אֶת־הָאָדָם בָּאָרֶץ

"And the LORD [5] ____ that he had made man on the earth."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
5	וַיִּנָּחֵם				see ↓
✓	וַיִּנָּחֵם	Wayyiqtol	3ms	נחם	Simple Action (Niphal-only) — relented

6:7

וַיִּנָּחֵם כִּי עָשִׂיתִם

"I [6] ____ that I made them."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
6	וַיִּנָּחֵם				see ↓
✓	וַיִּנָּחֵם	Weqatal	1cs	נחם	Simple Action (Niphal-only) — I regret

6:11

וַתִּשְׁחַת הָאָרֶץ ... וַתִּמָּלֵא הָאָרֶץ חֲמָס

"The earth [7] ____ ... and the earth [8] ____ with violence."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
7	וַתִּשְׁחַת				see ↓
✓	וַתִּשְׁחַת	Wayyiqtol	3fs	שחח	Passive — it was corrupted
8	וַתִּמָּלֵא				see ↓
✓	וַתִּמָּלֵא	Wayyiqtol	3fs	מלא	Passive — it was filled

6:12

וַהֲבֵינָה נִשְׁחָתָה כִּי־הִשְׁחִית כָּל־בָּשָׂר

"and behold, it [9] ____, for all flesh had corrupted its way."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
9	נִשְׁחָתָה				see ↓
✓	נִשְׁחָתָה	Weqatal	3fs	שחח	Passive — it was corrupt

6:21

וְהָיָה לָהֶם לְאֹכֶל וְלָהֶם לְאֹכֶל יֵאָכֵל

"it shall be food for you and for them — it shall [10] ____."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
10	יֵאָכֵל				see ↓
✓	יֵאָכֵל	Imperfect	3ms	אכל	Passive — it shall be eaten

Passage C — Genesis 21:23–31

21:23

הַשְׁבְּעָה לִי בְּאֵלֵהֶם הַנֶּה

"[11] ____ to me by God here."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
11	הִשָּׁבַעַה				see ↓
✓	הִשָּׁבַעַה	Imperative	2ms	שָׁבַע	Reflexive — Swear! (bind yourself by

21:24

וַיֹּאמֶר אַבְרָהָם אָנֹכִי אֲשָׁבַע

"And Abraham said, 'I [12] ____.'"

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
12	אֲשָׁבַעַ				see ↓
✓	אֲשָׁבַעַ	Imperfect	1cs	שָׁבַע	Reflexive — I will swear

21:31

כִּי שָׁם נִשְׁבָּעוּ שְׁנֵיהֶם

"For there [13] ____ both of them."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
13	נִשְׁבָּעוּ				see ↓
✓	נִשְׁבָּעוּ	Weqatal	3mp	שָׁבַע	Reflexive — they swore (bound

Bonus — Genesis 21:3, 21:8

21:3

אֲשֶׁר-נִוְלַד-לּוֹ

"who had been born to him"

21:8

וַיִּגְדַּל הַיֶּלֶד וַיִּגְמַל

"And the child grew and was weaned."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
B1	נִוְלַד				see ↓
✓	נִוְלַד	Weqatal	3ms	וָלַד	Passive — who had been born
B2	וַיִּגְמַל				see ↓
✓	וַיִּגְמַל	Wayyiqtol	3ms	גָּמַל	Passive — was weaned

Part C — Distractor Check

These three verbs come from the same passages. None are Niphal. Answer "No" for Niphal? and complete the full parse.

3:6

וַתֵּרָא הָאִשָּׁה כִּי טוֹב הָעֵץ לְמַאֲכָל

"So when the woman [D1] ____ that the tree was good for food."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
D1	וַתֵּרָא				see ↓
✓	וַתֵּרָא	Wayyiqtol	3fs	רָאָה	NOT Niphal — Qal: and she saw; III-■

6:6

כִּי עָשָׂה אֶת־הָאָדָם בְּאָרֶץ

"that he [D2] ____ mankind on the earth."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
D2	עָשָׂה				see ↓
✓	עָשָׂה	Perfect	3ms	עָשָׂה	NOT Niphal — Qal: he made/did; III-■

21:8

וַיִּגְדֹּל הַיֶּלֶד

"And [D3] ____ the child."

#	Verb	Conjugation	PGN	Root	Function
D3	וַיִּגְדֹּל				see ↓
✓	וַיִּגְדֹּל	Wayyiqtol	3ms	גָּדַל	NOT Niphal — Qal: and he grew; plain

Items 5–6 (■■■■■■■■■■ / ■■■■■■■■■■) are both from ■■■■■■, a verb that occurs almost exclusively in the Niphal. Items 11–13 all parse as Reflexive from ■■■■■■ — notice how Imperative, Imperfect, and Weqatal all express the same oath-swearing action.

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